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AI



Google denies AI search
features are killing website
traffic



Numerous studies indicate that the [shift to AI search features](#) and the use of [AI chatbots](#) are killing traffic to publishers' sites. But Google on Wednesday denied that's the case, at least in aggregate. Instead, the search giant says that total organic click volume from its search engine to websites has been "relatively stable" year-over-year and that average click quality has slightly increased.

"This data is in contrast to third-party reports that inaccurately suggest dramatic declines in aggregate traffic — often based on flawed methodologies, isolated examples, or traffic changes that occurred prior to the roll out of AI features in Search," writes Google VP and Head of Search, Liz Reid, in [a new blog post](#).

Though Google hasn't shared any specific data to back up its conclusions, even if we assume Google's claims to be true, this doesn't necessarily mean that AI isn't having an impact.

IMAGE CREDITS: [JOSE LUIS CARRASCOSA](#)

Even Google has to admit this, as Reid acknowledges that "user trends are shifting traffic to different sites, resulting in decreased traffic to some sites and increased traffic to others."

That word "some" is doing heavy lifting here, as Google doesn't share data about how many sites are gaining or losing. And while chatbots like ChatGPT have certainly seen traffic increase in recent months, that doesn't mean online publishers aren't suffering.



IMAGE CREDITS: GOOGLE

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Google has been revamping its search engine for years to answer more questions directly on the search results page, and now does so with AI through its “AI Overviews” that appear at the top of search results. Google also allows users to interact with an AI chatbot for some queries. Yet Google denies that this is significantly reshaping the search landscape. Rather, it points to users shifting their attention to other sites to start their queries.

Reid explains, “People are increasingly seeking out and clicking on sites with forums, videos, podcasts, and posts where they can hear authentic voices and first-hand perspectives.”

Reading between the lines, it seems like Google.com isn’t necessarily people’s first stop on the web these days. But that’s something we’ve known for some time. Back in 2022, a Google exec even said that social sites like TikTok and Instagram [were eating into Google’s core products](#), like Search and Maps.

“In our studies, something like almost 40% of young people, when they’re looking for a place for lunch, they don’t go to Google Maps or Search,” said Google SVP Prabhakar Raghavan, who ran the company’s Knowledge and Information organization at the time (he is now its chief technologist). “They go to TikTok or Instagram,” he noted.

Google has also long been worried that Amazon.com had become people’s first stop for online shopping searches, and Reddit.com had become the first stop for researching topics of interest.

Over many years, the company has tried to come up with compelling features for both consumers and retailers that would attract more users to Google Shopping. These efforts have included [universal shopping carts](#), [local inventory checks](#), [deal finders](#), [shopping from product images on websites](#), and more. It even [made its Shopping listings free](#) for merchants in 2020.

Meanwhile, as users [complained that Google Search quality was declining](#), the search giant was seeing so much demand for Reddit that it finally [added a “Reddit” filter](#) to allow users to narrow down results on relevant search queries. (Now that filter simply reads “forums.”)

So perhaps there's some truth in Google's denials — it's not AI that's entirely responsible for killing search. Search was already dying.

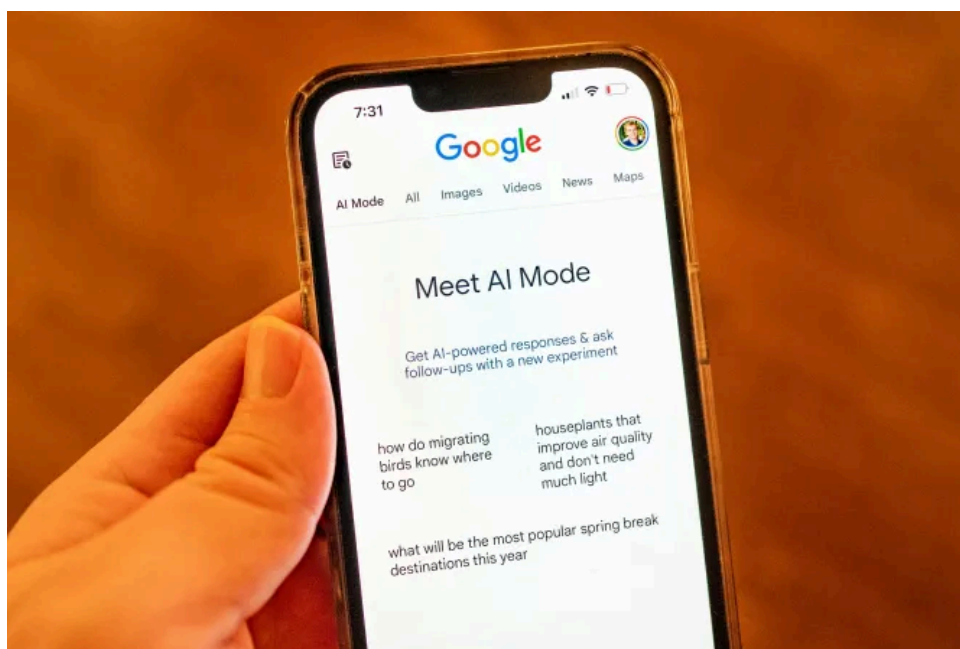


IMAGE CREDITS: SMITH COLLECTION/GADO / GETTY IMAGES

Google's new blog post also attempts to move the goalposts a bit about what it means for websites receiving Google's clicks. Now, instead of counting clicks, it wants publishers to think about click quality.

The company says average click quality has increased, and Google is sending "slightly more quality clicks" to websites than a year ago. (Google explains that a quality click is one where users don't quickly click back — they stay and read.) How much of an increase, though, Google doesn't say. The company only points out that when people click through on an AI response to the source, they're more likely to dive deeper, so those clicks are more valuable.

What's more, Google paints AI as an opportunity for web publishers to gain increased exposure, saying that "with AI Overviews, people are seeing more links on the page than before," Reid writes. "More queries and more links mean more opportunities for websites to surface and get clicked."

But AI, [while a growing referral source](#), isn't [yet making up the difference](#) in terms of clicks, reports have shown. One recent study from Similarweb indicates that the number of news searches on the web resulting in zero clicks to news websites has grown from 56% (when Google launched AI Overviews in May 2024) to 69% as of May 2025.

Organic Traffic to News Sites vs. Zero-Clicks Search Share
US, Desktop & Mobile Web, Jan 2024 - May 2025

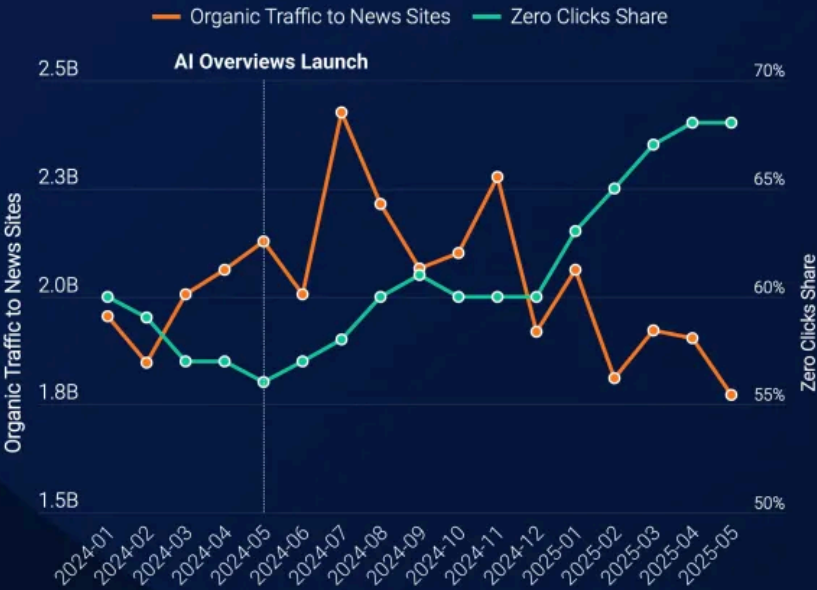


IMAGE CREDITS:SIMILARWEB

Google appears to know this is a trend, too, as it recently launched [a product for publishers](#) that helps them monetize their dwindling traffic in other ways that don't rely only on advertising, like micropayments or newsletter sign-ups.

The fact that Google is pushing this “AI is not the end of search traffic!” PR now only makes the situation seem more dire. It's as if Google wants publishers to believe not what their own eyes — and graphs and charts — tell them, but instead take comfort in the fact that Google still sends “billions of clicks to websites” every day, just as the post claims.

Topics: [AI](#) [Google](#) [media](#) [Media & Entertainment](#) [publishers](#)

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Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | X Twitter Instagram LinkedIn

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having previously spent over three years at...

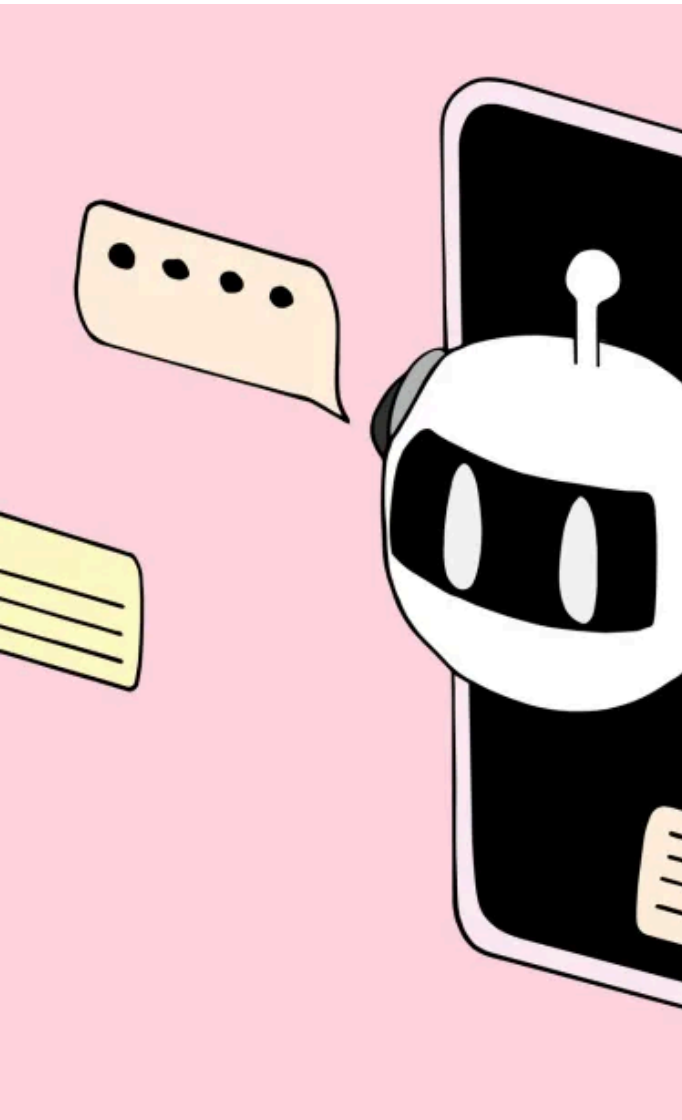


IMAGE CREDITS: MALORNY / GETTY IMAGES

AI



News publisher files class action antitrust suit against Google, citing AI's harms to their bottom line

Sarah Perez — 9:56 AM PST · December 15, 2023

A new class action lawsuit filed this week in the U.S. District Court in D.C. accuses Google and parent company Alphabet of anticompetitive behavior in violation of U.S. antitrust law, the Sherman Act, and others, on behalf of news publishers. The case, filed by Arkansas-based publisher Helena World Chronicle, argues that Google “siphons off” news publishers’ content, their readers and ad revenue through anticompetitive means. It also specifically cites new AI technologies like Google’s Search Generative Experience (SGE) and Bard AI chatbot as worsening the problem.

In the complaint, Helena World Chronicle, which owns and publishes two weekly newspapers in Arkansas, argues that

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Google is “starving the free press” by sharing publishers’ content on Google, losing them “billions of dollars.”

In addition to new AI technologies, the suit points to Google’s older question-and-answer technologies, like the “Knowledge Graph” launched in May 2012, as part of the problem.

“When a user searches for information on a topic, Google displays a ‘Knowledge Panel’ to the right of the search results. This panel contains a summary of content drawn from the Knowledge Graph database,” the complaint states. “Google compiled this massive database by extracting information from Publishers’ websites — what Google calls ‘materials shared across the web’ —and from ‘open source and licensed databases,’” it says.

By 2020, the Knowledge Graph had [grown](#) to 500 billion facts about 5 billion entities. But much of the “collective intelligence” that Google tapped into was content “misappropriated from Publishers,” the complaint alleges.

Other Google technologies, like “Featured Snippets” where Google algorithmically extracts answers from webpages, were also cited as shifting traffic away from publishers’ websites.

More importantly, perhaps, is the suit’s tackling of how AI will impact publishers’ businesses. The problem was recently detailed [in a report on Thursday by The Wall Street Journal](#), which led with a shocking statistic. When online magazine The Atlantic modeled what would happen if Google integrated AI into search, it found that 75% of the time the AI would answer the user’s query without requiring a click-through to its website, losing it traffic. This could have a major impact on publishers’ traffic going forward, as Google today drives nearly 40% of their traffic, according to data from Similarweb.

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Some publishers are now trying to get ahead of the problem. For example, [Axel Springer just this week inked a deal with OpenAI](#) to license its news for AI model training. But overall, publishers believe they'll lose somewhere between 20-40% of their website traffic when Google's AI products fully roll out, The WSJ's report noted.

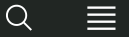
The lawsuit reiterates this concern, claiming that Google's recent advances in AI-based search were implemented with "the goal of discouraging end-users from visiting the websites of Class members who are part of the digital news and publishing line of commerce."

SGE, it argues, offers web searchers a way to seek information in a conversational mode, but ultimately keeps users in Google's "walled garden" as it "plagiarizes" their content. Publishers also can't block SGE because it uses the same web crawler as Google's general search service, GoogleBot.

Plus, it says Google's Bard AI was trained on a dataset that included "news, magazine and digital publications," citing both a 2023 [report](#) from the News Media Alliance and [a Washington Post article about AI training data](#) for reference. (The Post, which worked with researchers at the Allen Institute for AI, had found that News and Media sites were the third largest category of AI training data.)

The case points to other concerns, too, like changing
AI content and evidence of information distortion of

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[month with the Canadian government](#) which would see the search giant paying Canadian media for use of their content. Under the terms of the deal, Google will provide \$73.5 million (100 million Canadian dollars) every year to news organizations in the country, with funds distributed based on the news outlets' headcount. Negotiations with Meta are still unresolved, though Meta [began blocking news in Canada in August](#), in light of the pressure to pay for the content under the new Canadian law.

The case also arrives alongside the filing of the U.S. [Justice Department's lawsuit against Google](#) for monopolizing digital ad technologies, and references the 2020 Justice Department's [civil antitrust suit](#) over search and search advertising (which are different markets from digital ad technologies in the more recent suit).

"The anticompetitive effects of Google's scheme cause profound harm to competition, to consumers, to labor, and to a democratic free press," reads an [announcement](#) posted to the website of the law firm handling the case, Hausfeld.

"Plaintiff Helena World Chronicle, LLC invokes the Sherman Act and Clayton Act to seek class-wide monetary and injunctive relief to restore and ensure competition for digital news and reference publishing and set up guardrails to preserve a free marketplace of ideas in the new era of artificial intelligence," it states.

A Google spokesperson offered a statement on the lawsuit, saying "This lawsuit is meritless. People have many ways to

access information and news content today – through publishers’ websites, dedicated apps, social media platforms, print papers and more. Google links people to publishers’ websites more than 24 billion times each month – at no cost to them.”

The complaint is available below.

[Helena World Chronicle, LLC v. Google LLC and Alphabet Inc](#)
by [TechCrunch](#) on Scribd

[SCRIBD]

Case 1:23-cv-03677-APM Document 1 Filed 12/11/23 Page 1 of 96

IN THE UNITED STATES DISTRICT COURT
FOR THE DISTRICT OF COLUMBIA

HELENA WORLD CHRONICLE, LLC

Plaintiff,

v.

GOOGLE LLC and ALPHABET INC.,

Defendants.

CLASS ACTION COMPLAINT

JURY TRIAL DEMANDED

COMPLAINT

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Editor’s note: This post was updated after publication with a statement provided by Google on Friday evening.

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Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having previously spent over three years at...

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The Google News tab in Search is being redesigned for readability

Sarah Perez — 8:39 AM PDT · July 12, 2019

The Google News tab is getting a makeover. Google announced this week, [by way of a tweet](#), a significant redesign of the Google.com News tab on the desktop, which will organize articles in a card-style layout, while also better emphasizing publisher names. The end result makes Google News more aesthetically pleasing, but it comes at the expense of information density.

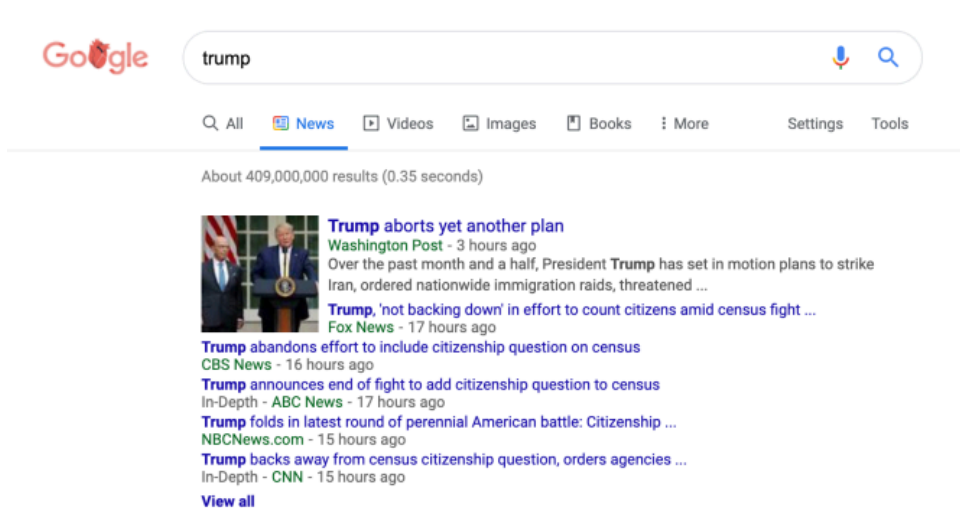
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To be clear, the changes here are focused on the News *tab* of Google.com — not the dedicated Google News product at news.google.com. You land on the News tab when you search for a term on Google.com, and then click over to “News” to see the latest coverage instead of Google’s list of search results.

As the preview of the redesign shows, news articles are currently organized in a compact list of links, allowing you to see several headlines around a single topic with just a glance. This design, admittedly, is a bit old-school — but it works.

Within the stack of links, the headline is blue, the publisher is green and the articles are labeled as “In-depth” or “Opinion,” when relevant. There are small photo thumbnails by the lead story, with other publishers’ links underneath appearing as only text.



The updated design is more readable, as articles are spaced out and placed in cards, similar to the main Google News product. There’s more white space and longer previews of each story, as well.

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But the change means you're seeing far fewer results on the screen before you have to scroll down.

Over the next couple weeks we're rolling out a redesigned News tab in Search on desktop. The refreshed design makes publisher names more prominent and organizes articles more clearly to help you find the news you need. Check it out

👉 pic.twitter.com/xa2aZfO4Qd

— Google News Initiative (@GoogleNewsInit) [July 11, 2019](#)

The updated News tab makes it more obvious where the news is coming from, because publishers' names are given more prominence. They also get their logo next to the headline, so it's easier to identify your favorite news outlets with a glance. This is reminiscent of the recent mobile redesign for Google Search, which also [put increased attention on the publishers](#) by featuring them at the top of a link alongside their logo.

In addition to providing you with a set of News search results, the redesigned tab includes a new carousel labeled "People also searched for" that points you to other relevant news based on your search query.

Not everyone is thrilled about the update, given it makes it more difficult to quickly scan a number of headlines at once. And because there are fewer publishers' articles on the first screen, traffic to those "[below the fold](#)" will likely drop.

Google says the changes will roll out over the next couple of weeks.

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